

Oil absorption

If pigment particles were the same smooth shape, size, and weight, they would all need the same amount of oil to coat their surfaces. In fact, each pigment needs a specific amount of oil to reach a desired uniform consistency. Paint with less oil content is less flexible and is liable to crack if you paint it over a color with high oil absorption. This can be avoided using the “fat-over-lean” rule (see pp.58-59).



High oil content (70% or more)

Pigments include Burnt Sienna, Raw Sienna (above), Burnt Umber, Winsor Blue and Green, Alizarin, Permanent Rose, and Cobalt.

Medium oil content (50-70%)

Cadmium Yellow, Cadmium Red (above), Raw Umber, Oxide of Chromium, and Ivory Black are included in this category.

Low oil content (50% or less)

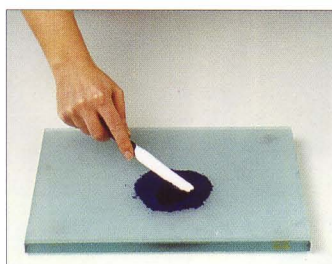
Only a few pigments are included here: Ultramarine (above), Manganese Blue, and Flake White.



1 ▲ Place a small heap of pigment powder in the center of a glass slab and make a well in the middle of the powder. Then pour a small amount of linseed oil into the well.

Mixing oil paints

Making your own oil paints is not difficult. You need a ground glass slab and a flat-bottomed glass muller (these are also available in hard stone, such as granite), a large palette knife, cold-pressed linseed oil, and some pigment powder. Avoid using toxic pigments such as Lead White or Cobalt Blue, as they are too dangerous. You should use a dust mask whenever you grind powder colors.



2 ◀ Use the palette knife to mix the oil and pigment into a stiff paste. You may find this is easier to do with some pigment powders than with others.



3 ◀ Place the muller on top of the paint mixture and start to grind it with a continuous, smooth circular action. Use the palette knife to scrape any paint from the edge of the muller and the sides of the glass slab back into the middle.



4 ▲ When the paste has achieved a creamy consistency, scrape it off and store it in a small, airtight jar.

Materials



Airtight jar



Palette knife



Glass slab and muller

Modern commercial paints

Commercial oil paints are sold in tubes, and most manufacturers produce two lines: artists' and students'. Artists' paint is of a higher quality, as it contains the best pigments and has the highest proportion of pigment to drying oil. The price of individual colors largely depends on the cost of the raw material used to obtain that particular color. The wide range of cheap, bright, lightfast synthetic pigments now available are a good option.



Cadmium Red is a lightfast, opaque color that was introduced in the early twentieth century.



Transparent artificial Ultramarine replaced the natural pigments made from lapis lazuli in the nineteenth century.

